

6.2 Databases

For understanding databases, we will have to think about data. A database can be defined as a collection of data—any data—as long as the data is related to each other. First of all, you will need to understand why we need to use a database. A very generic example would be movies. If you are a movie freak, you will want to sort your movie collection depending on the title, type of media, price of each movie and other relevant aspects. You will also need to update this database regularly.

Again, we can use movies as a very good example of data meant for a database since the data are interrelated. For instance, a movie title can be correlated with the cast. So you can have a database that contains separate tables for movie name, actors, and so on and relate it with each other. Now, if you had to sort this out in an Excel spreadsheet, it would be quite a large spreadsheet. Moreover, the search and query feature is not available in Excel.

In a database, you must specify the fields you want to enter into the database, and use a form or manually fill the database. The job is much easier using Access. You can print custom reports and query and sort data according to your preferences.

For creating a new database, click the 'Create a New file' link in the task pane on the right-hand side of the screen. On the next screen, under the 'Templates' heading, click 'My Computer', and in the dialog box that appears, click 'Databases'. Then choose the database type that most closely matches your need. Here, we choose 'Inventory Control' since we want to sort our movies.



Creating a database